

52 Jephthah

An outcast who became Gilead's deliverer, and whose rash vow ended in grief.

Jephthah was a warrior from Gilead, east of the Jordan. He was the son of a harlot, and his half-brothers drove him from home. He gathered a band of men in the land of Tob. Years later, when the Ammonites pressed Israel, the elders who had rejected him came asking for help. Jephthah became their head, argued Israel's case with the king of Ammon, and then won a great victory when the Spirit of the LORD came upon him. But before the battle he made a vow, and his only daughter was the first to come out to meet him. His story holds real faith and tragic rashness side by side. Hebrews still names him among the heroes of faith.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yiphtach</i> , usually explained as "he opens"
Family	Son of Gilead by a harlot; one daughter, his only child (Judges 11:1, 34)
When	The period of the judges, after Jair. No firm date
Judged	Six years (Judges 12:7)
Key places	Gilead, the land of Tob, Mizpeh of Gilead, the fords of the Jordan
Key people	The elders of Gilead, the king of Ammon, his daughter, the men of Ephraim
Main passages	Judges 10:6–12:7
New Testament	Hebrews 11:32

"Now Jephthah the Gileadite was a mighty man of valour, and he was the son of an harlot: and Gilead begat Jephthah."

Judges 11:1, KJV

The life of Jephthah

No calendar dates. Jephthah's "300 years" (Judges 11:26) is cited for the early Exodus date; others take it as a round number.

Before his call	● Ammon oppresses Gilead For eighteen years the Philistines and Ammonites oppress Israel. Israel cries out, puts away its idols, and serves the LORD again. <i>Judges 10:6-16</i>
Early life	● Driven out Gilead's sons by his wife thrust him out. He flees to the land of Tob, where "vain men" gather to him. <i>Judges 11:1-3</i>
Ammon attacks	● Called home The elders of Gilead ask him to be their captain. He agrees if he becomes their head, sealed before the LORD in Mizpeh. <i>Judges 11:4-11</i>
Before the battle	● Argues Israel's case He tells the king of Ammon that Israel took the land from the Amorites, and leaves the case to "the LORD the Judge." <i>Judges 11:12-28</i>
The campaign	● Vows and wins The Spirit of the LORD comes upon him. He vows that whatever comes out of his house to meet him will be the LORD's, offered as a burnt offering. He defeats Ammon across twenty cities. <i>Judges 11:29-33</i>
Coming home	● His daughter meets him His only child comes out with timbrels and dances. He tears his clothes. She asks for two months to mourn her virginity on the mountains, and then he does "according to his vow." <i>Judges 11:34-40</i>
Afterward	● War with Ephraim Ephraim complains that it was not called to fight. Jephthah's men hold the Jordan fords and test fugitives with the word "Shibboleth." He judges Israel six years, dies, and is buried in Gilead. <i>Judges 12:1-7</i>

Key activities

Readers differ on what Jephthah's vow meant for his daughter. Many believe he offered her as a burnt offering, a grave sin the law forbade; others believe he gave her to lifelong, unmarried service of the LORD, pointing to the stress on her virginity (Judges 11:37–39).

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- 1 **Rose from rejection.** Thrust out by his brothers, he became leader of a band of men in Tob. *Judges 11:1–3*
 - 2 **Made terms with the elders.** He agreed to fight only if Gilead made him head, and he spoke all his words before the LORD in Mizpeh. *Judges 11:4–11*
 - 3 **Tried words before war.** He sent messengers to the king of Ammon and argued from Israel's history. *Judges 11:12–27*
 - 4 **Trusted the Judge.** He left the dispute with "the LORD the Judge." *Judges 11:27*
 - 5 **Led by the Spirit.** The Spirit of the LORD came upon him, and he passed through Gilead and Manasseh to meet Ammon. *Judges 11:29*
 - 6 **Made a rash vow.** He promised God whatever first met him as a burnt offering if he gave victory. *Judges 11:30–31*
 - 7 **Won the victory.** The LORD delivered Ammon into his hands, from Aroer to Minnith. *Judges 11:32–33*
 - 8 **Kept his word in grief.** "I have opened my mouth unto the LORD, and I cannot go back." *Judges 11:35*
 - 9 **Fought fellow Israelites.** When Ephraim threatened him, forty-two thousand Ephraimites fell at the Jordan. *Judges 12:1–6*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jephthah.

Old Testament

Judges 10:6–12:7	The main account
1 Samuel 12:11	Named among the deliverers God sent
Numbers 21:21–31; Deuteronomy 2:26–36	The history he retold to Ammon
Echo: Ecclesiastes 5:5	Better not to vow than to vow and not pay
Echo: Genesis 22:11–12	God stopped Abraham's hand over Isaac

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32–33	Named among those who "through faith subdued kingdoms"
Echo: Matthew 5:33–37	Jesus warns against careless oaths
Echo: Matthew 21:42	"The stone which the builders rejected"

For discussion

- Observe:* What did the elders of Gilead promise Jephthah, and where was it sealed (Judges 11:8–11)?
- Understand:* Jephthah had real faith (Hebrews 11:32), yet he made a rash vow. How can both be true of the same person?
- Apply:* Jephthah was rejected by his family and later called back. How might God use a hard part of your past?
- Apply:* Is there a promise you made quickly, to God or to someone else, that you need to think through or keep this week?